

Q How soon can I start expressing and giving my baby a bottle?

This can depend on your reasons for expressing. If you want breast milk for your premature baby, you can start expressing right away in the hospital. If you are breast-feeding, you might want to wait until it is well established.

Waiting a few weeks before giving your baby expressed milk in a bottle will allow her to develop her sucking technique, which for breast-feeding involves coordinating her tongue and jaw movements in a unique action. Feeding from a bottle is very different, since gravity rather than your baby's sucking brings the milk to your baby, and the milk flow tends to be faster.

Introducing a bottle (and by the same token a pacifier) in the early weeks of breast-feeding can lead to the phenomenon known as "nipple confusion," whereby your baby loses the sucking action needed for breast-feeding and, together with frustration at the slower flow of milk, shows a preference for feeding from a bottle. However, not all babies experience nipple confusion—some happily take to a bottle and are happy to switch between a breast and a bottle.



Giving expressed milk Once breast-feeding is well established, you should be able to feed your baby from the breast and give her expressed milk in bottles.

Q Should I be expressing my breast milk at a particular time of day?

There are no set rules about when you should express. Some experts recommend expressing after a feeding, so that you don't remove milk your baby would have fed on, but if you are confident that your supply is plentiful, you can express either before or after a feeding.

If you express before a feeding, do this away from your baby so that she doesn't smell your milk or see your breasts and then want to start feeding. Women often find their supply of milk is most abundant in the morning after a night's sleep, so after your baby's first feeding of the day can be a good time to express.

Once you grow more confident expressing, you can pump one breast while your baby is feeding from the other one. Your breasts will replace whatever milk is removed so you don't need to worry about your supply running out.

Q I can express only a few drops of milk at a time. Does this mean I'm not producing enough breast milk?

Your breasts are almost certainly producing enough milk. Don't judge your overall supply on how much milk you manage to express. While some women fill bottles effortlessly, others don't find it as easy. Perhaps expressing works best for you by producing smaller amounts more frequently. Each woman is different.

Some women who find that expressing is unproductive have thriving, growing babies and are clearly producing enough milk. Your baby's sucking is by far the most effective way of extracting milk, so even if you aren't producing much when you express, she is almost certainly extracting more when she is feeding.

There are ways to help stimulate your letdown reflex (see p.269). Tension can hinder the letdown of your milk, so get comfortable and relaxed. Taking a warm shower or putting a warm washcloth on your breast can help. Choose a time when you are less likely to be interrupted, pick a quiet spot, have a hot beverage, and listen to some music if it helps. Massaging your breasts can help your milk to start flowing—use circular movements and then stroke downward toward your nipples. Try to think about your baby when you start to express—imagine you are feeding or cradling her—since this can trigger the letdown reflex.

It is normal for the smell, color, and consistency of **expressed breast milk** to vary depending on what you have eaten.

Q Are there any guidelines on how breast milk should be stored and how long I can keep it?

Always refrigerate or freeze your expressed milk right away. Pour breast milk into a sanitized container—a plastic bottle, specially sanitized breast milk bag, or ice-cube trays (these smaller quantities are very handy for quick defrosting). Always make a note of the date on the container.

Your milk will keep in a refrigerator kept at 39°F (4°C) or lower for three to eight days. Store it at the back since the temperature can fluctuate near the door. You can also store it in the freezer compartment of a refrigerator for two weeks, or for three to six months in the freezer attached to your refrigerator if there are separate doors and if it's kept at 0°F (-18°C). If you have a deep freezer kept at -20°C (-4°F), it can stay for six to 12 months. Defrost frozen milk overnight in the refrigerator or by running cool, then warm water over it. Do not microwave.



Did you know...

Breast milk contains substances that either relax or stimulate your baby depending on the time of day. Relaxing nucleotides are present in the evening and stimulating ones found earlier in the day.